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NSF Call for Public Input on Federal AI Plan

Content of Submission

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We appreciate the opportunity to participate in OSTP and NSF's Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan and to provide input on priority actions that should be included in the Federal AI Action Plan.

Overview of Anthology and its services

Anthology delivers education and technology solutions so students can reach their full potential and learning institutions thrive. This includes focusing on global institutions in higher education, government, and corporations preparing students for advanced degrees, certifications, and on-the-job training. Millions of students around the world are supported throughout their education journey via Anthology's market-leading ecosystem of flagship SaaS solutions and support services, including the award-winning Blackboard® Learning Management Solution (LMS), Anthology® Student, Student Information System and Enterprise Resource Planning (SIS+ERP), and Anthology® Reach Customer Relationship Management (CRM) solutions.

Through the power of education and technology, we are uniquely empowering educators and institutions with meaningful, simple, and intelligent innovation to help them redefine what's possible and create life-changing opportunities for people everywhere. Artificial intelligence (AI) is a transformative technology that supports our customers today and will continue to do so well into the future. From our discussions with university, government, and business leaders, we know the conversation around implementing AI is shifting away from reticence to a focus on unlocking its potential to drive more personalized experiences for students, enhance institutional efficiency, and achieve better outcomes for all.

AI is reshaping education, offering personalized learning, accessibility, and greater efficiency. For students, AI provides individualized support; and for faculty, it

streamlines administrative tasks and allows educators to focus on teaching and learning. Institutional leadership will also benefit from AI-driven predictive analytics. Our customers are at a pivotal moment — enrollment is declining, and retention challenges are creating financial strain. Analytics that provide early warning signs that a student needs additional support and identify at-risk students are critical. This enables leaders to intervene and provide better support for those students. The promise of AI and its potential benefits for students, faculty, and higher education institutions is too great to allow this moment to pass without critical evaluations and clear guidance on its ethical use.

Our deliberate approach is to provide clear guidance and direction on using AI in the classroom through an [AI Policy Framework](#) to help higher education institutions who are interested in developing and adopting specific policies and programs on the ethical use of AI within their institution. We recognized that our customers needed assurance and a foundation of trust before they would be willing to adopt this disruptive technology.

Education leader in trustworthy AI

The trustworthy use of AI has, therefore, been a key priority for Anthology for a long time, and we have been actively thinking about AI risk management for years. In 2018, Anthology brought institutions and academics together to discuss [Ethical AI in Higher Education](#).

Since then, Anthology has held various customer webinars and sessions to show how Anthology manages AI risks responsibly. In 2022, we established a cross-functional working group to implement a dedicated Trustworthy AI program. In 2023, we formally implemented our Trustworthy AI Program, which is led by a Global Privacy Officer and overseen by a Trustworthy AI Council. Our Trustworthy AI program is aligned to the U.S. [NIST AI Risk Management Framework](#). The program builds on and integrates with Anthology's ISO-certified privacy and security risk management programs and processes.

A transformative technology with promises and risks

Higher education leaders and faculty face mounting challenges, including increasing administrative burdens, evolving workforce skill requirements, and as noted previously, declining enrollment. AI can help by automating time-consuming tasks, streamlining content creation, and freeing faculty to focus on high-impact interactions with students. Additionally, AI-driven insights can support data-informed decision-making, enabling institutions adapt to shifting student needs and market demands.

While the opportunities with AI are promising, every new and powerful technology comes with risks. Before any technology is widely adopted, technology companies like Anthology must work hard to gain the necessary trust from customers, employees, and partners. We need to convince our customers and society at large that we manage these risks appropriately, that we can be trusted, that the technology itself can be

trusted. At the same time, companies like Anthology rely on government entities to establish the necessary frameworks and rules that build trust in AI and ultimately drive its adoption

When automobiles were first introduced, many consumers were hesitant to adopt this new form of transportation due to concerns about safety and reliability. It took time for regulations and safety standards to be implemented, as well as for public perception to shift toward accepting cars as a safe and reliable mode of transportation. The same is true for AI. Inaccurate outputs, security risks, lack of transparency and control are just some of the risks that need to be managed to allow for the safe and responsible use of AI.

Introducing AI to the Classroom

Alongside the introduction of the Trustworthy AI Framework, we launched our first AI-powered product features, enabling our clients to explore the technology while also being confident that they were in control of its ultimate use in the classroom.

Blackboard is the first major LMS to leverage generative AI to inspire course and assessment creation tasks, setting the standard for instructor efficiency. The AI Design Assistant (AIDA) in Blackboard provides educators inspiration for course and assessment creation enabling them to spend less time on administrative tasks and more time focused on their students.

AIDA is already significantly enhancing instructor efficiency. Instructors report a 50% reduction in the time it takes to develop a course, allowing them to redirect that time toward engaging with students, providing mentorship, and ensuring student success.

Since its launch, 675 institutions have enabled the feature, resulting in instructors engaging with the feature more than 1.3 million times. Introducing AI to faculty first was by design. Faculty were initially wary of AI, not only due to concerns about students using tools like ChatGPT to complete assignments rather than engaging in the learning process themselves, but also because of the real issues inherent in AI-detection and plagiarism tools.

Our approach of engaging faculty and stressing that they were always in control of the output was imperative to the success we have had with their adoption of the AI feature. As AI continues to transform higher education, fostering AI literacy is essential to preparing students for a future where these technologies will be integral to their academic and professional success.

The AI Conversation Tool in Blackboard is designed to cultivate responsible AI engagement, providing students with hands-on experiences in leveraging generative AI while understanding its limitations. By embedding AI literacy into curricula, institutions can empower students to critically assess AI-generated content, apply ethical considerations, and develop the skills needed to navigate an evolving technological

landscape. This approach aligns with Anthology's Trustworthy AI Framework, ensuring that AI adoption in education remains transparent, secure, and human-centered.

We are also working on an AI Class Scheduling Assistant in our student information system, Anthology Student. The AI Class Scheduling Assistant uses conversational AI to help users analyze scheduling needs, allowing them to ask the assistant questions typically buried in multiple reports. By responding to text-based inquiries, this assistant provides valuable insights into class offerings and hiring needs, improving cost-efficiency and enabling institutions to adapt their scheduling to student needs.

To showcase these AI features and to discuss the crucial topic of trustworthy AI, Anthology launched an [Ethical AI in Action World Tour](#) in October 2024, a 25-stop global tour that brought thousands of education professionals from around the globe together. With both a national and international audience, the feedback was consistent. The biggest challenge in incorporating AI-driven tools is a lack of clarity and confidence among education professionals, with a significant need for training and familiarity with AI tools. Transparency is highlighted as the top priority for ethical AI use.

We have expanded on the global roadshow, now offering a series of virtual sessions, and an AI Literacy Course for educators. This course provides the foundations for understanding artificial intelligence in education, supporting instructors in developing the practical skills they need to boost student engagement through AI technologies. It also addresses ethical AI policies in educational settings around course creation, assessment, and instruction under Anthology's trustworthy AI approach of "humans in control". Faculty learn useful strategies for delivering a successful e-learning experience while leveraging AI technology responsibly and more confidently.

We are now expanding our use of AI as we design a virtual reality experience that will allow remote students to be part of the classroom experience, driving a more "hands-on" remote learning experience.

Looking ahead

At Anthology, providing value to our customers and our organization by leveraging AI is a top priority. We have established an executive AI Working Group to coordinate AI-related efforts across the company. Furthermore, we have created an AI Center of Excellence (AiCE). The AiCE brings together cross-functional experts who are passionate about AI and committed to advancing its effective use. Our objective is to help employees adopt AI in a sustainable and cost-effective manner which aligns with business goals, innovation strategies, and the principles of trustworthy and ethical AI use.

As AI technology and its adoption rapidly develop, we understand that our efforts to manage the related risks need to keep pace. For years, we have been committed to high standards in data privacy and security, which has led to more mature programs and external recognition through certifications such as ISO 27001/27701, SOC2, and

FedRAMP. We are taking the same approach for our Trustworthy AI program. We use the NIST AI Risk Management Framework as our “north star”, with action plans to enhance our program and controls regarding the responsible use of AI. We also do this in anticipation of increased and rapid development of legislative and regulatory efforts worldwide to regulate AI risks.

Recommended federal AI policy actions

Education institutions have historically been more cautious in adopting new technologies than other sectors. However, much like with previous examples of disruptive technologies, the resistance to AI today stems from uncertainties around its safety, security, and ethical implications. As with previous technologies, addressing these concerns through transparency, rules, and oversight will build trust and broader acceptance of AI among consumers.

We therefore encourage the U.S. government to work with U.S. state legislators and international counterparts to create a regulatory environment with consistent and predictable rules that balance innovation and risk.

With the right balance, we are confident that this transformative technology will not only thrive but propel us and our customers to new heights—expanding global access to education, delivering more personalized student experiences, and driving improved outcomes across higher education, government, corporate learning environments, and beyond.

Because we are the global subject matter experts on the application of AI in education, we would welcome the opportunity to serve on a committee or provide guidance and support as OSTP and NSF consider legislation and the advancement of AI. From our firsthand experience in education, we have learned that a careful balance is key to accelerating the adoption of new and advanced technologies. We are also acutely aware that as this technology evolves, our educational institutions will be at the forefront of teaching the next generation to rethink how they work, learn, and operate in any field or industry. Pivotal to our success is a solid educational infrastructure grounded on ethical use, personalizing student experiences, and reaching the masses in both a traditional on-campus and remote learning experience.

With advancements in AI supported by a confident public and an education system that is the envy of the world, the United States will lead innovation on a global scale, create life-changing opportunities, drive economic growth, and strengthen our national security.

Appendix - Anthology resources

- Trustworthy AI statement: <https://www.anthology.com/trust-center/trustworthy-ai-approach>
- AI Policy Framework for customers: https://www.anthology.com/sites/default/files/2024-08/AI-Policy-Framework_v1_08-24.pdf

- Research paper: AI in Higher Ed: Hype, Harm, or Help:
<https://www.anthology.com/paper/ai-in-higher-ed-hype-harm-or-help>

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